Gupta Empire (c. 319 - 550 CE)

Capital: Pataliputra (modern Patna, Bihar)

Period: 4th-6th century CE

Known as: The Golden Age of India

Foundation & Rise:

- Founded by Chandragupta I around 319 CE, marking the start of the Gupta Era.
- Expanded rapidly under Samudragupta, recorded in the Allahabad Pillar Inscription.
- Reached peak under Chandragupta II (Vikramaditya), extending from Bengal to Kathiawar.

Key Rulers:

1. Chandragupta I (319-335 CE) - Founder; alliance with Lichchhavis.
2. Samudragupta (335-375 CE) - 'Napoleon of India' for conquests.
3. Chandragupta II (375-415 CE) - Defeated Shakas; patron of arts.
4. Kumaragupta I (415-455 CE) - Founded Nalanda University.
5. Skandagupta (455-467 CE) - Repelled Hunas; decline began.

Administration:

- Monarchy with decentralised governance.
- Provinces (Bhuktis) managed by Uparikas; districts (Vishayas) run by Vishayapatis.
- Land revenue as main income; gold coins (Dinars) circulated.

Economy & Trade:

- Prosperous agriculture with irrigation.
- Trade in silk, spices, gems with Southeast Asia & Mediterranean.
- Urban centres like Ujjain, Pataliputra thrived.

Culture & Achievements:

- Religion: Hinduism dominant; patronised Buddhism & Jainism.
- Literature: Works by Kalidasa (Shakuntala, Meghaduta).
- Science: Aryabhata - zero, pi, planetary motion.
- Art: Ajanta murals, Udayagiri caves, iron pillar of Delhi.

Decline:

- Huna invasions in 5th-6th centuries weakened empire.
- Internal divisions led to fall by ~550 CE.

Legacy:

- Political stability, prosperity, and cultural brilliance.
- Influence lasted for centuries in Indian civilisation.